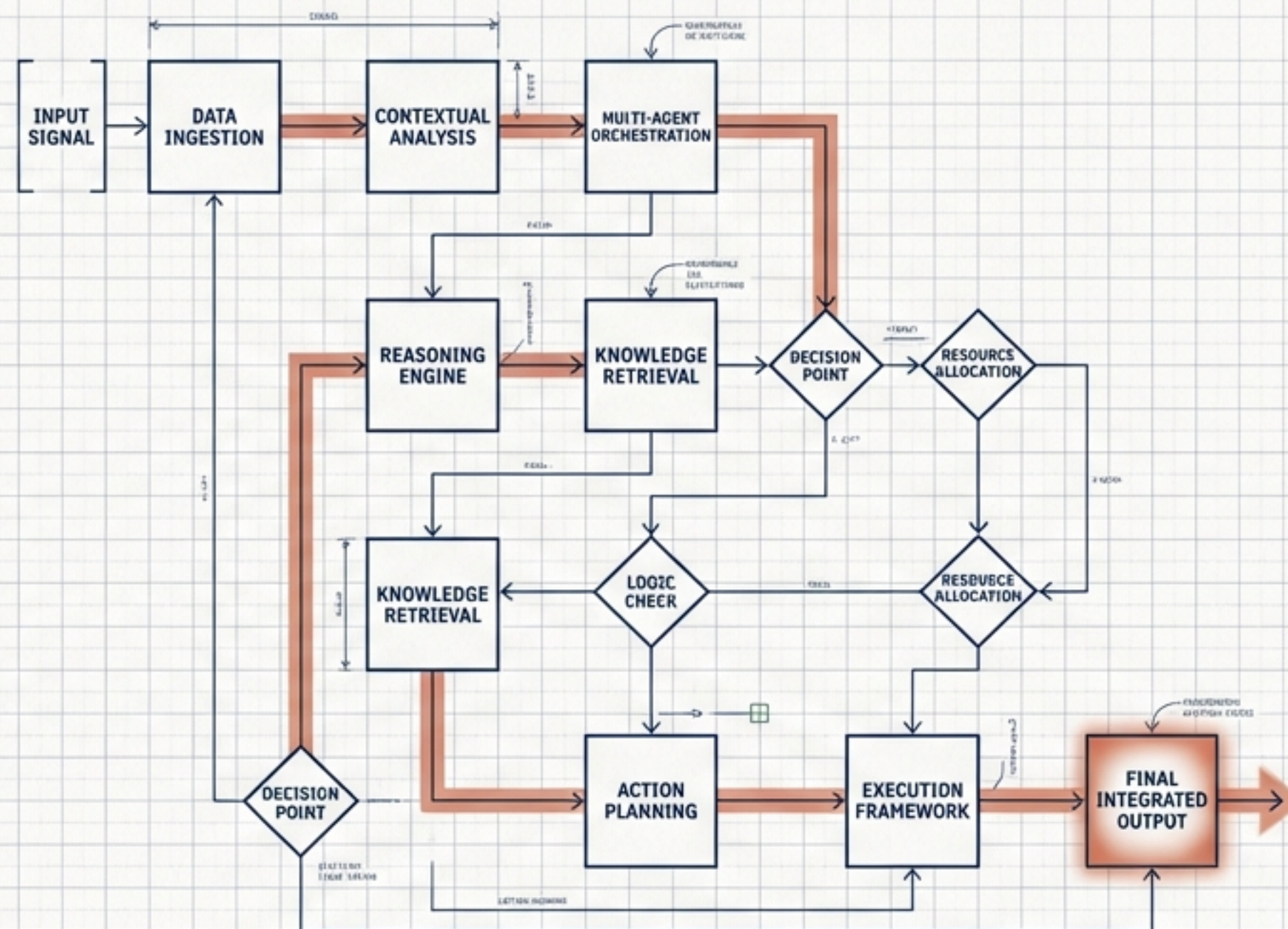


Five AI Trends Shaping 2026

The Evolution of Agentic Workflows

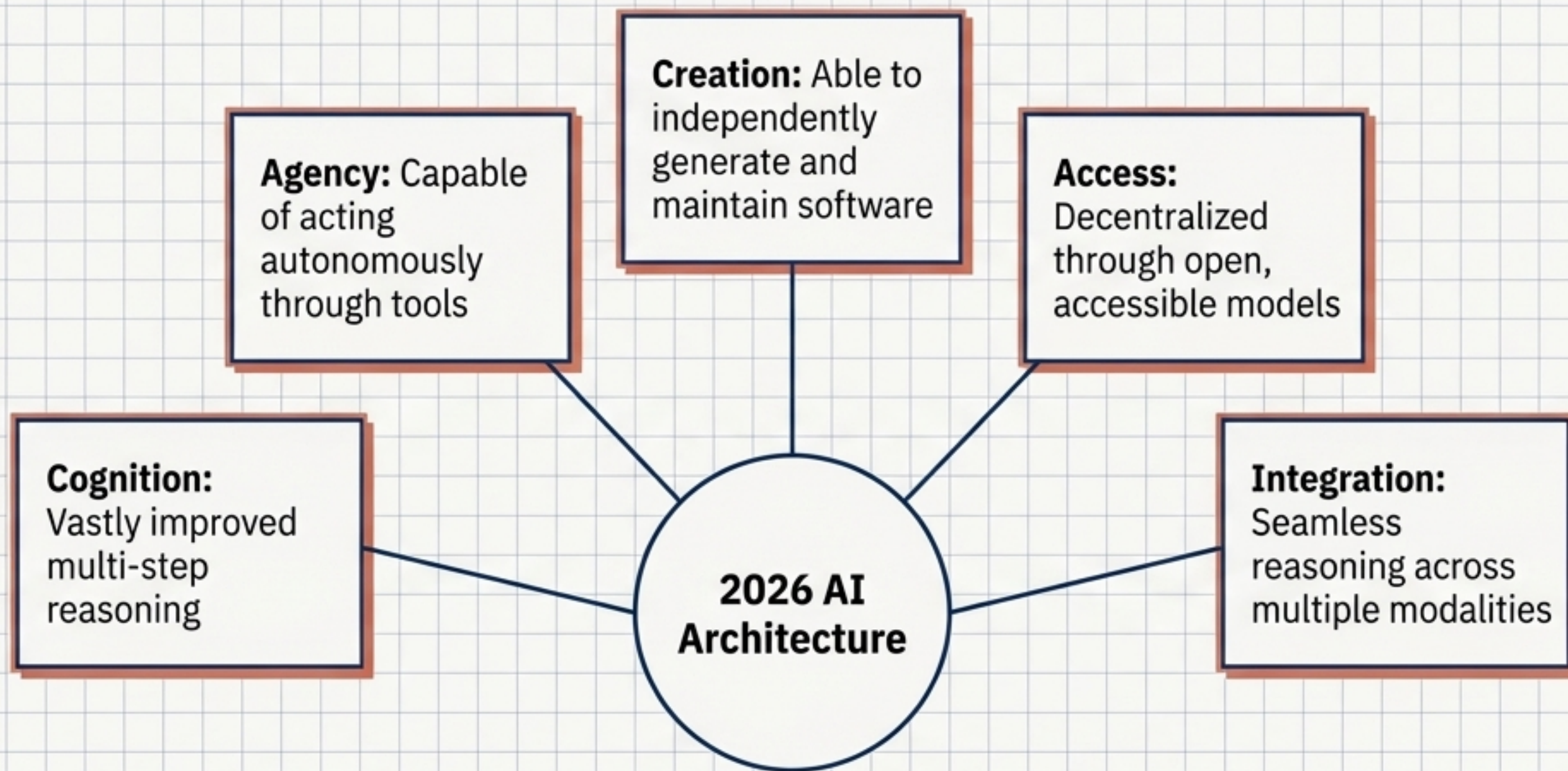
- Rapid shift from reactive chatbots to proactive agents
- Breakthroughs in hardware efficiency and local computing
- Evolution of training: from human feedback to verifiable logic
- Transition from isolated text tools to integrated digital workers



CORE CONCEPT:

Welcome to the future of AI. The systems we are building for 2026 are fundamentally changing because we are no longer just teaching them to talk; we are teaching them to think and act.

The Overall Direction of AI Development



Macro Perspective: AI is evolving from a passive tool you query into an active participant in digital workflows. These five pillars define the next generation of systems.

From Reacting to Reasoning

Legacy Models

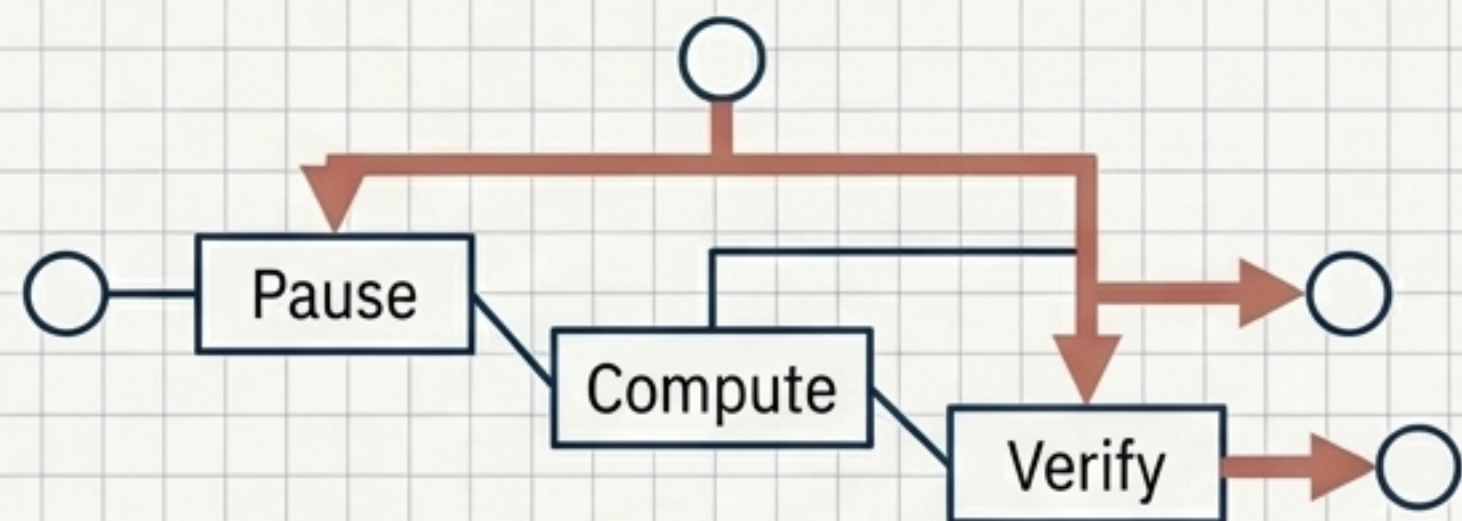


Token-by-Token
Generation

The Flaw: Early chatbots generated text immediately, failing complex math or coding tasks.

Training: RLHF (Human Feedback)

2026 Models

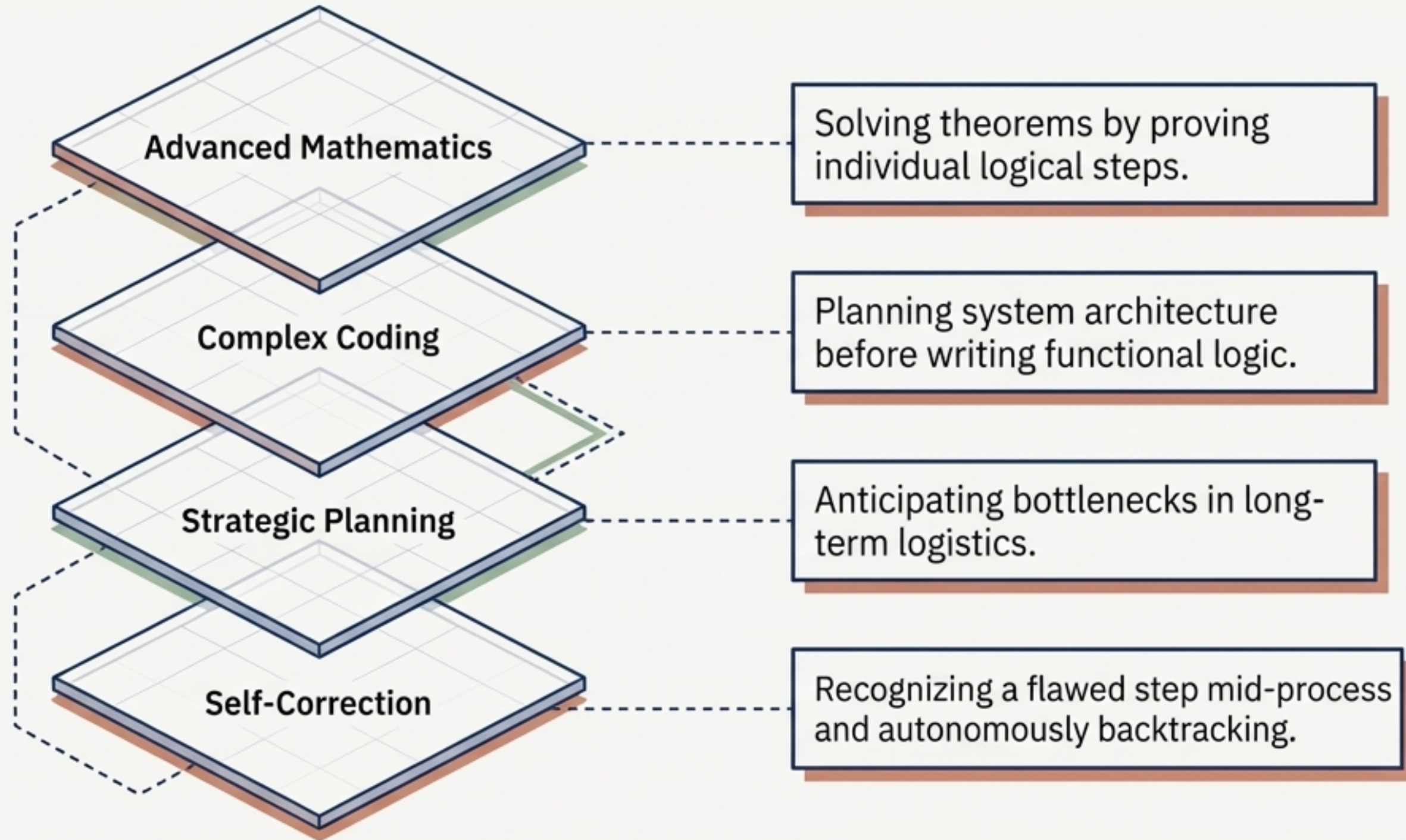


The Fix: New models break problems into steps, dynamically adjusting compute power based on task complexity.

Training: RLVR (Verifiable Rewards - automatic checks and tests)

Core Concept: Early AI blurts out the first answer. 2026 models take out a scratchpad, work through the logic, and systematically verify their own work before speaking.

The Power of Multi-Step Thinking



Core Concept: Multi-step thinking allows AI to tackle rigorous, zero-mistake environments like software engineering and high-level mathematics.

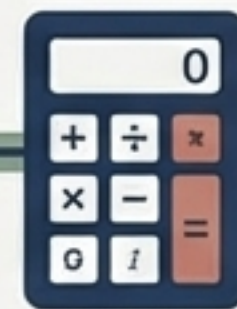
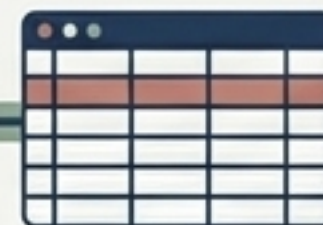
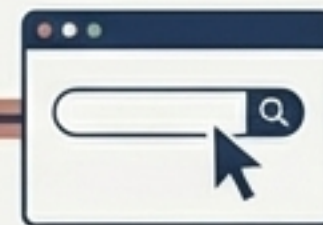
From Answering to Acting



The Oracle: Only provides answers



The Actor



Tool Usage: Agents decide when and how to trigger external tools independently.

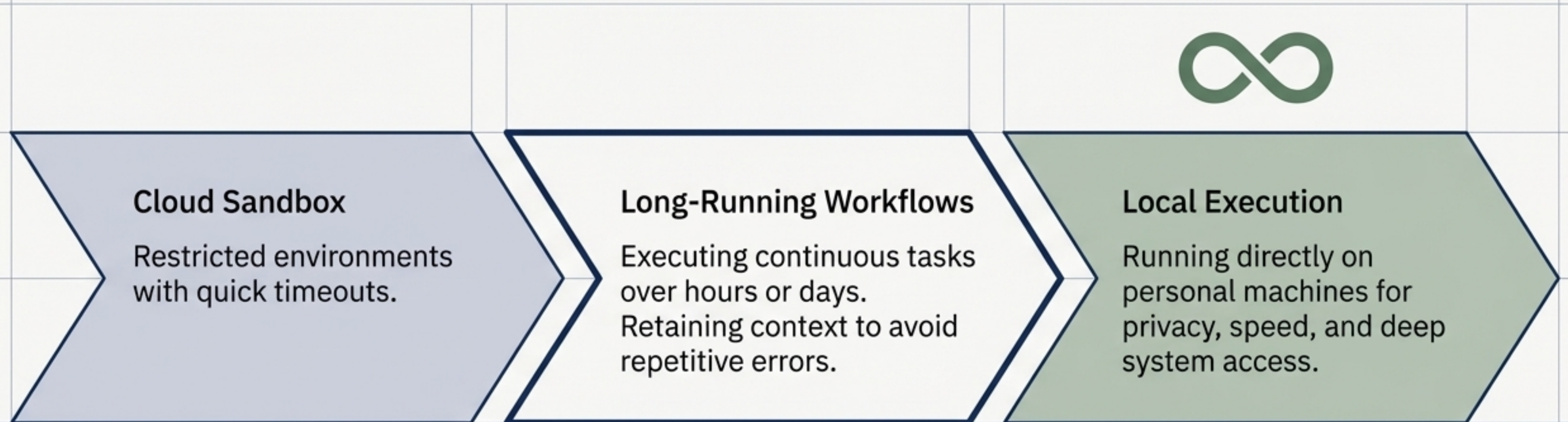
Workflow Execution & Limitations

Execution: Capable of stringing together distinct actions to achieve a larger goal.

Limitation: Long workflows still struggle with context loss and accumulating errors over time.

Core Concept: We are moving from AI as a static encyclopedia to AI as an active intern, though current agents can still lose track of long-term goals.

The Next Leap: Persistent Agents



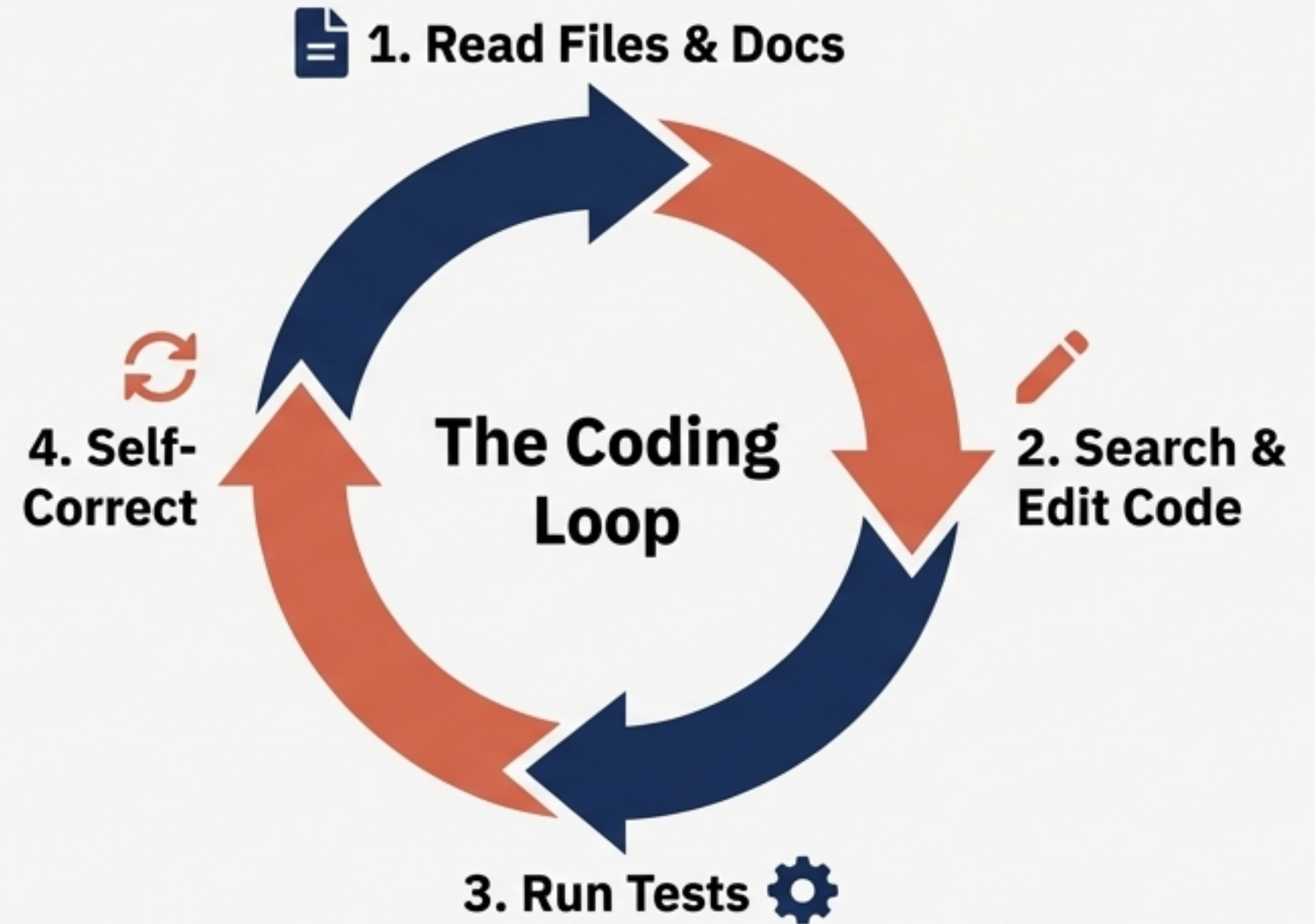
Summary Callout

Core Concept: By 2026, agents will not just run for five seconds in the cloud. They will live on your laptop, working persistently in the background for days.

The Autonomous Developer

Beyond Autocomplete

Moving from predicting a few lines of code to understanding entire code repositories. Models are trained on real-world codebases, system documentation, and run locally.



Summary Callout

Core Concept: AI is evolving into a junior developer capable of iterating in loops—writing code, testing it, seeing the error, and fixing it without human intervention.

Democratizing AI Access

The API Era



Top-tier models locked behind corporate, cloud-only APIs. Centralized control and high computational costs.



The Open Shift

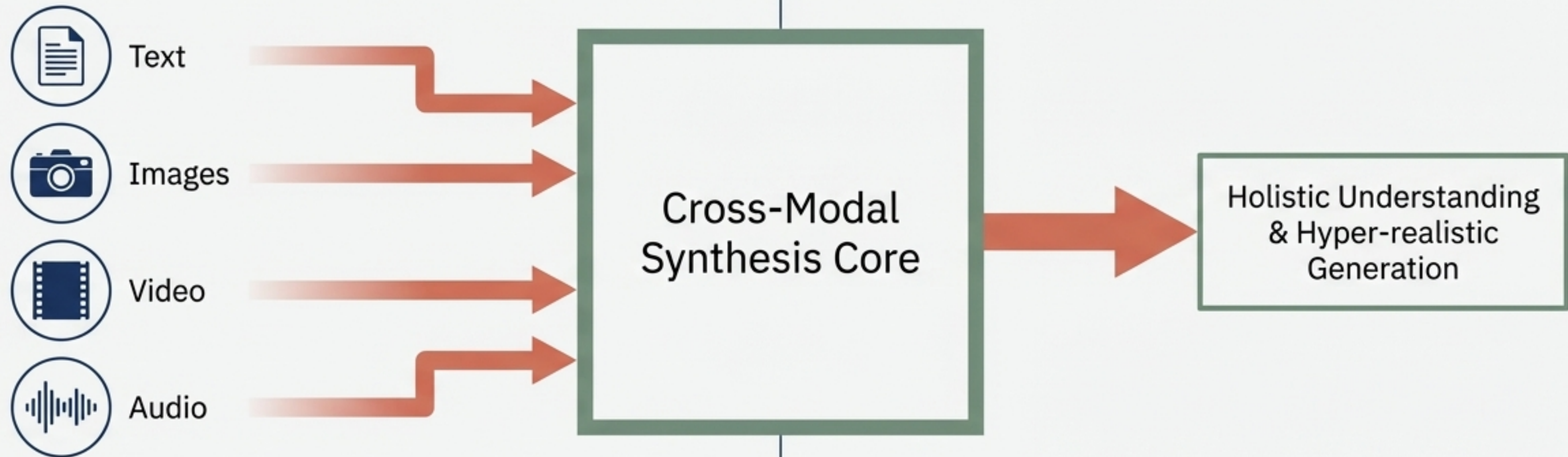


Developers download, run, and fine-tune open-weight models locally. Self-hosting ensures data privacy, reduces costs, and prevents vendor lock-in.

Summary Callout

Core Concept: Architectural efficiency has made running powerful AI on consumer hardware practical, putting immense capability into the hands of individual developers.

Perceiving the World



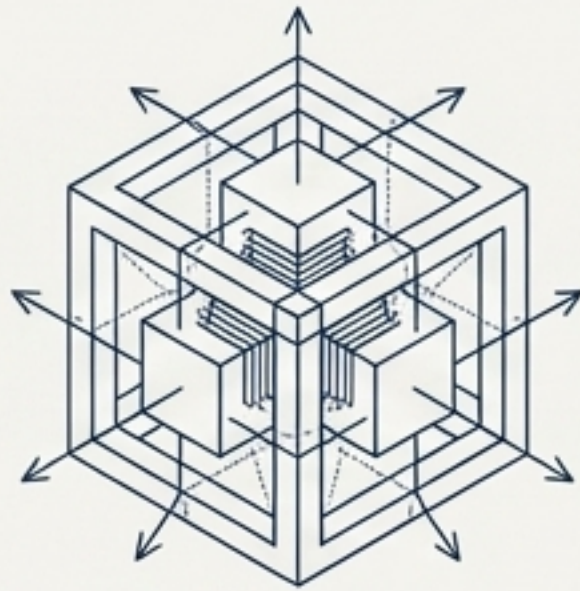
Sensory Integration: Processing multiple data formats simultaneously.

Cross-Modal Reasoning: Connecting concepts across different formats in a single interaction without relying solely on human text.

Summary Callout

Core Concept: Imagine an AI that watches a video of a mechanical failure, listens to the engine sound, and outputs a written repair manual.

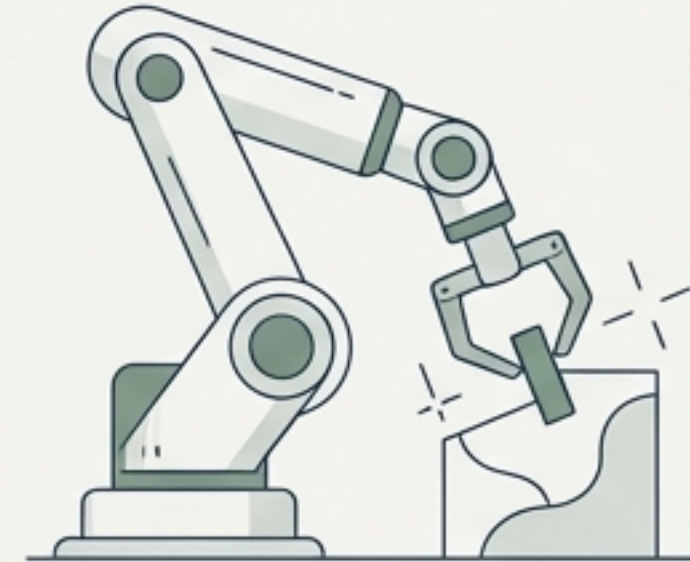
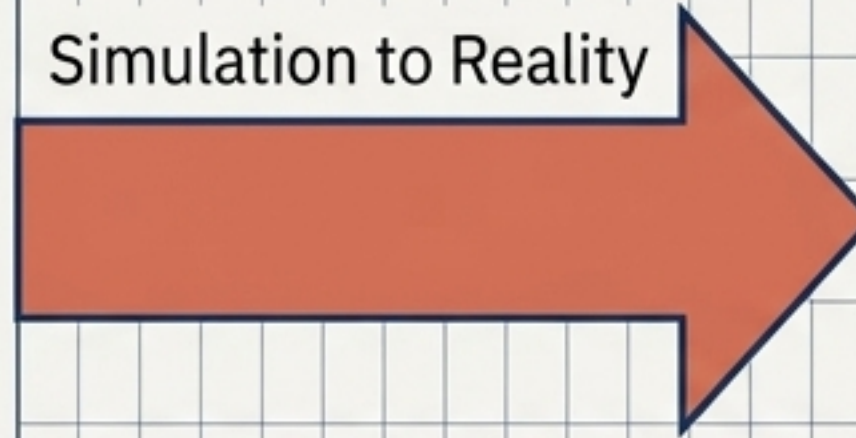
Beyond the Screen



World Models

AI systems that internally simulate complex physics and 3D spatial environments.

Simulation to Reality



Physical AI

Embedding multimodal reasoning into robots to safely navigate real-world environments.

Spatial Intelligence: AI is transitioning from simply understanding language to understanding space and time, safely training in digital models before deployment.

Core Concept: The final frontier is the physical world. Internal simulations allow us to train physical robots to navigate our spaces with the fluency AI navigates text.

The 2026 Paradigm Shift

	Past Paradigm	2026 Shift
Software	Writing <u>manual syntax</u>	Managing <u>AI coding agents</u>
Automation	Fragmented, <u>static scripts</u>	Managed by persistent local <u>agents</u>
The Human Role	Manual execution & solo contribution	Directing goals, orchestrating <u>workflows</u> , <u>verifying logic</u>

Summary Callout

Core Concept: Your future career will look less like a solo contributor and more like a manager. You will guide, verify, and string together fleets of specialized AI agents.

Shaping the Future of Work

Discussion Prompts:

01 / Engineering

If coding AI can manage entire repositories, what is the core value of a human software engineer in 2026?

02 / Security

What are the security and ethical risks of a 'persistent local agent' running continuous workflows with deep access to your personal machine?

03 / Creativity

How might RLVR (verifiable rewards) fail or constrain systems when applied to creative, subjective, or unstructured tasks?

Summary Callout

Core Concept: As the builders and managers of these future systems, consider how these agentic trends will impact and redefine your chosen career paths.